

BOGURODZICA

The two oldest stanzas with their melody

Critical edition

Edited from Kraków, Biblioteka Jagiellońska, MS 1619

2026

Bogurodzica is the oldest surviving Polish religious song. Its first two stanzas, addressed to the Virgin and to Christ, form the original song; later copies add up to twenty more. The only medieval copy with music for both stanzas is a flyleaf of BJ MS 1619, written shortly after 1400. This edition gives that melody in square notation, with the text of the same copy, an apparatus of musical and textual variants, and notes on the manuscript.

Edition

Cant. I

B o-gu-rodzi- ca dzie-wi- ca, Bogiem sławie- na Ma- ry- ja, U twe-go sy- na, Gospo-
dzi- na, Matko zwo- le-na, Ma- ry- ja! Zyszczy nam, spuści nam. Ky-ri- e e- le- i-son.

2. Twe- go dzie- la Krzci- cie- la, bo- ży- ce, u- słysz gło- sy, na- pełń myś- li czło- wiec- ze. Słysz
mo- dli- twę, jąż no- si- my, a dać ra- czy, je- goż pro- si- my: a na świe- cie zbożny po- byt,
po ży- wo- cie rajski prze- byt. Ky-ri- e e- le- i-son.

Bar lines are editorial. Neume groups follow κ.

Text

Diplomatic (κ; ϧ = nasal vowel)

Bogv rodzicza dziewicza bogem sławena maria
Vtwego syna gospodzina matko swolena maria
Ssziszczi nam spwczci nam kyrieleyson
Twego dzela krzcziczela boszicze
Vslisz glosi naplen misli czlowecze
Slisz modlitwę yqsz nosimi
A dacz raczi gegosz prosimi
a naswecze zbożni pobith
posziwocze raski pzbith ky'eleyson

Critical

*Bogurodzica dziewica, Bogiem sławiena Maryja,
u twego syna Gospodzina matko zwolena, Maryja!
Zyszczy nam, spuści nam. Kirielejson.
Twego dzieła Krzcziciela, Bożyce,
uśłysz głosy, napętn myśli człowiecze.
Słysz modlitwę, jaż nosimy,
a dać raczy, jegoż prosimy:
a na świecie zbożny pobyt,
po żywocie rajski przebyt. Kirielejson.*

Translation. *Mother of God, Virgin glorified by God, Mary! Chosen Mother, Mary, win for us from thy Son the Lord, send down to us. Kyrie eleison.*

For thy Baptist's sake, Son of God, hear our voices, fulfil the thoughts of men. Hear the prayer we bring, and deign to grant what we ask: on earth a godly life, after life a dwelling in paradise. Kyrie eleison.

Sources

Musical witnesses

- κ Kraków, Biblioteka Jagiellońska, MS 1619, back flyleaf. Base text. Added to a copy of Latin sermons made by Maciej of Grochów, vicar of Kcynia; before 1408. Stanzas 1–2 with music, in seven systems. Gothic chant notation of German–Messine type, C and F clefs, no custodes. A decorated initial opens each musical section: *B(ogu)*, *U (twego)*, *Z(yszczy)*, *T(wego)*, *U(śłysz)*, *S(łysz)*, *A (dać)*.
- κ70 Kraków, Biblioteka Jagiellońska, manuscript of 1570. Leans towards B flat before cadences on a.
- w Warsaw, library of the Literati Chapel at St John's, MS 998 D. Mensural notation, the only witness with written rhythm.
- CZ Częstochowa, Jasna Góra, late 15th century. Lost; known from a drawing reproduced by Woronczak. Music for the first two lines of stanza 1 only.
- GN The Gniezno cathedral melody, printed in *Przyjaciel Ludu* 4, no. 46 (Leszno, 1838), p. 364. It sets the whole text, with smaller note values and sharps.
- z Warsaw, Zamoyski Library, MS 1152 (1672). Mensural; the κ70 version, less accurately written.

Readings of κ70 and w are given after Chybiński (1907, pp. 30–41), who sets them out in modern notation. CZ, GN and z are described but not collated.

Text witnesses

- κ408 Kraków, BJ MS 408, f. 87^v. Added in the early 15th century to a codex dated 1408. Stanzas 1–14, no music.
- WA Warsaw, Biblioteka Narodowa, from Holy Cross, c. 1456. 19 stanzas.
- CZ as above.
- κ3 Kraków, first half of the 16th century. 23 stanzas.

- Ł Jan Łaski, *Commune incliti Poloniae Regni privilegium* (Kraków: J. Haller, 1506), first in the *Registrum*, attributed to St Adalbert. No music.
- M Mateusz z Kościana, 1543. H Herburt, 1570. s Skarga, *Żywoty świętych*, 1579.

Pilat (1879) and Kalina (1880) number the Kraków copies the other way round, calling BJ 408 “Kraków I”. The sigla here follow the shelfmarks.

Editorial method

1. The melody and text are those of κ. The transcription was made from the facsimile and agrees in every pitch with Chybiński’s (1907).
2. Pitch is fixed by the clefs of κ: final D, range C–d’, mode 1. With a C clef on the fourth line, gabc c d e f g h i j k equals C D E F G a b c’ d’. The single b, on *spuś-ci*, is natural.
3. κ has no rhythmic signs, so the score has none.
4. The text is normalised after Woronczak (1962), keeping the *u* that κ writes and sets to music at the start of line 1.2.
5. Bar lines mark the verse structure.

Musical apparatus

Pitches C D E F G a b c’ d’; hyphens join notes on one syllable. (?) marks readings Chybiński thought corrupt.

Loc.	Lemma	Readings
1.1	<i>Bogurodzica</i>	κ D C F E-D-C D κ70 D D-C F E-C-E D w D C F E D
1.2	<i>dziewica</i>	κ F G-F-G a κ70 F G b flat a w F G a
1.3	<i>Bogiem sławiena</i>	κ c’ d’ c’ a-G-F F κ70 b d’ c’ a-G F (?) w c’ d’ c’ a F
1.4	<i>Maryja</i>	κ F-G-a-G E-C D κ70 F-a-G-E C E D (?) w F a G E D D (?)
1.5	<i>U twego syna</i>	κ d’ c’ a-G-F G-F-G a κ70 a G F G b flat a a w short form beginning on a; κ70 and w both lack d’ c’
1.6	<i>Gospodzina</i>	κ c’ d’ c’ a G F κ70 c’ d’ c’ a-G F w c’ d’ c’ a F
1.7	<i>Matko</i>	κ c’ a-G-F κ70 c’ a-G (?) w c’ a
1.8	<i>zwolena, Maryja</i>	as 1.4 in all witnesses
1.9	<i>Zyszczy nam</i>	κ F G-F-G a κ70 F G b flat a w F G a
1.10	<i>spuści nam</i>	κ w c’ b d’ κ70 c’ b d’ d’ (?)
1.11	<i>Kyrie</i>	κ c’ a G-F κ70 w c’ a F
2.1	<i>Twego dzieła Krzcziciela</i>	κ D-E D-C F G E C D κ70 D D-C F F G G E E C D D (?) w D D-C F G E C-E D
2.2	<i>Bożyce</i>	as 1.4 in all witnesses
2.3	<i>uśłysz głosy</i>	κ a G-F G-F-G a κ70 a G-F G b flat a w a G-F G a a

Loc.	Lemma	Readings
2.4	<i>napęłń myśli człowiecze</i>	κ D C F G E C D κ7o w <i>napęłnij</i> , with an extra note
2.5	<i>Słysz modlitwę, jąż nosimy</i>	κ C F G E-D-E C D E D κ7o C G a b flat a a D D C C F F E D w C F G a D D C F G a a
2.6	<i>a dać raczy</i>	κ a G-F G-F-G a κ7o a G F G b flat a a (?!)
2.7	<i>jegoż prosimy</i>	κ D-E D-C F G a κ7o D D-C F G b flat a
2.8	<i>a na świecie zbożny pobyt</i>	κ c' a c' G c' a-G-F G-F-G a κ7o c' b c' d' G G c' a G G b flat a w a c' d' G G c' a F G a a
2.9	<i>po żywocie rajski przebyt</i>	κ a c' d' G c' a-G-F G-F-G a κ7o a b flat c' d' G c' a F F b flat a w a c' d' G c' a F G a a
2.10	<i>Kyrieieison</i>	κ a G F F-G-a-G E D D

Textual apparatus

Variants are normalised; spelling differences are ignored.

Loc.	Lemma	Variants
1.1	<i>Bogu rodzica</i>	κ K408 <i>Boga rodzica</i> WA CZ K3 Ł M H S
1.1	<i>śławiena</i>	κ K408 <i>śławiona</i> WA CZ K3 Ł M H S
1.2	<i>U twego</i>	κ WA CZ K3 Ł H S <i>W twego</i> K408 M
1.2	<i>Gospodzina</i>	κ K408 WA CZ Ł M <i>gospodina</i> K3 <i>Gospodynia</i> H <i>hospodyna</i> s
1.2	<i>zwolena</i>	κ K408 <i>zwolona</i> WA Ł M H S <i>zbolenia</i> CZ <i>zwolienia</i> K3
1.3	<i>Zyszczy ... spuści nam</i>	κ K408 WA Ł <i>zyszczysz ... spuszczysz</i> CZ <i>zyszczy ... spust winam</i> K3 M <i>ziścisz ... spuścisz</i> H <i>ziści ... spuści</i> s
2.1	<i>Twego dzieła</i>	κ K408 WA CZ <i>Twego syna</i> K3 Ł M H S
2.1	<i>Krzyciela</i>	<i>zbawiciela</i> M [Kr]ziciela <i>zbawiciela</i> K3
2.1	<i>Bożyce</i>	κ K408 <i>zbożnica</i> WA CZ <i>zbożny czas</i> Ł H S <i>zbożnika</i> M
2.2	<i>napęłń</i>	κ <i>napęłni</i> K408 WA CZ K3 Ł M H S
2.3	<i>jaż nosimy</i>	κ K408 WA <i>jenżeć nosimy</i> CZ <i>jenże (cię) prosimy</i> Ł M H S
2.4	<i>A dać raczy</i>	κ WA <i>Oddać raczy</i> K408 M <i>O dać</i> CZ <i>O o dać</i> Ł <i>O o daci</i> H <i>To dać</i> s
2.5	<i>a na świecie</i>	κ K408 <i>daj na świecie</i> WA CZ Ł H S <i>daj nam na świecie</i> M <i>dai na świecie</i> <i>dobry</i> K3
2.5–6	<i>pobyt ... przebyt</i>	<i>pobyt</i> κ ... <i>przybytk</i> WA
2.6	<i>rajski</i>	raski κ
refr.	<i>Kirielejson</i>	kyrieleyson κ (st. 2 ky'eleyson) kyon CZ kyeon WA <i>Kyrie eleison</i> M H S

Notes

Staves and clefs. System 1 has four lines, the rest five; the lowest line also serves as the text baseline. In system 2 the clefs move for *Matko* and return before *zwolena*. Read with these clefs, *Matko* is c' a-G-F.

1.1 *Bogv rodzicza* is two words, with the dative *Bogu* in a genitive sense (Łoś). All other copies have *Boga rodzica*, the name used in the 1410 *Chronica conflictus* and by Długosz. *Sławiena* and *zwolena* are Old Polish forms, not Czechisms. The C on -gu- is faint but legible.

1.2 *U*: two separate puncta, d' c', carry the syllable. The later musical witnesses drop both notes and so lose the octave leap from *Maryja*. Over -dzi-na of *Gospodzina* the a and G stand close and the F apart, which gives c' a-G | F.

2.1 *dziela* means 'for the sake of' (later *dla*). Łoś knew it in no other Old Polish text and used it to date the song to the 13th century. The printed tradition replaced it with *syna*; modern popular texts misread it as *dziela*. *Bożyce* is the vocative of *bożyc*, 'son of God'.

2.2 The C on -pełn is not visible in the facsimile; only the D over naplen can be read. It is supplied from the parallel 2.1 and from every other transcription.

2.4 The initial of *A dać* has the same design as the *U* of *Usłysz*. This likely explains Pilat's reading O dacz; Łoś, Kalina and Woronczak read A.

2.4–10 From *A dać raczy* the neumes are larger and more widely spaced, possibly in another hand (Chybiński). The forms and pitches are the same as before.

Commentary

Form. Each stanza has three parts: two parallel lines, then a contrasting third with the refrain (Łoś). The melody varies four short phrases (Surzyński's *a–d*), all traceable to the first line, which turns almost symmetrically on c'–d'–c' (Flotzinger; Perz calls the procedure centonate). The cadence of *Maryja* returns at *zwolena*, the second *Maryja* and *Bożyce*. *Dziewica* returns at *zyszczy nam, usłysz głosy* and *a dać raczy*. *Twego dziela Krzciciela* returns at *napeln myśli człowiecze*, and the end of *a na świecie zbożny pobyt* at *po żywocie rajski przebyt*.

Mode. The final is D, with inner cadences on a and F. Chybiński weighed mode 6 because of the F cadences, but settled on mode 1. B appears once, at the melodic peak on *spuści*.

Date and origin. Attribution to St Adalbert (d. 997) begins with 15th- and 16th-century copies, Łaski among them, and no modern scholar accepts it. Łoś placed the text in the late 13th century on linguistic and metrical grounds; Chybiński and Feicht put the melody at the turn of the 13th and 14th centuries. Woronczak (1952) matched the opening phrase to the Holy Saturday litany *Kyrie* in the Graz gradual MS 807 and read the song as a *Kyrie trope*. Flotzinger (2005) showed that the match covers only the first phrase, placed the Graz manuscript at Passau c. 1170, and rejected the trope reading. He dates the song to the late 14th century, in south-eastern Poland with Czech mediation. Feicht (1962) assembled many parallels, among them Jehan de Braine's *Par dessous l'ombre d'un bois*, and judged the melody the coherent work of one trained musician. Pikulik (2005) argues that the octave leap after the first *Maryja* rules out a date before the 12th or 13th century and calls the melody a 13th-century cento. Kalina (1880) heard two melodies by different authors; Feicht's analysis superseded this.

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